

A Pattern Language of Advocacy

Fourteen patterns in four rings, read off the record

Michel Garand | September 2026 | Version 0.1 | CC BY-SA 4.0

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Written to be given away. This is the pattern form of a method set out at length elsewhere: an advocacy reference that holds the record and the figures, a plain-language guide that holds the argument, a case history that holds the observation behind three of the patterns, and a general statement of the method. Each pattern below is a card in the form this collection already uses — the tension, what was observed, the pattern, its connections, its open questions, its status — with the record standing in for field notes. Read the cards in order once; after that, enter anywhere. This document was developed with assistance from Claude (Anthropic PBC). All strategic decisions and commitments are those of the author.

How to read this

A pattern language is not a list of rules. It is a web of named relationships across scales, each pattern stating a tension that recurs, what has been observed about it, and a resolution that has held — connected to the patterns it depends on and the ones it supports. Alexander built the form for buildings; this collection uses it for a place. Here it is used for advocacy: the craft of trying, on purpose and together, to change what people think, feel, or do, for someone or something that cannot do it alone.

The rings are scales, from the smallest outward:

- **Ring 0 — The opening.** One pattern: the question everything else answers.
- **Ring 1 — The point.** The single real thing shown, and the person who owns the showing.
- **Ring 2 — The work.** What is made, how it returns, what it refuses to say.
- **Ring 3 — The carriers.** Where the work is placed, for whom, and how it is allowed to change.
- **Ring 4 — The environment.** The information weather the work is placed into, and what it must survive.

Status is one of three: *converged* — the pattern appears in movements that never designed it, on more than one continent; *measured* — at least one published attribution or natural experiment stands behind it; *designed* — proposed, not yet demonstrated by an instance built from it. Where a pattern is designed only, the card says so.

Every figure quoted on a card is drawn from the advocacy reference published alongside this document, which cites its sources by name. Nothing here is new; everything here is shorter, and shaped to be assembled.

Ring 0 — The opening

Pattern 1 — What If

The tension. Advocacy usually opens with a claim, and a claim can be rebutted. The audience's most comfortable position is futility — nothing can be done, so nothing is asked of me — and the advocate's is argument — being right is comfortable; showing and then staying quiet is not. Each side's comfort protects the other's.

What was observed. The lasting successes in the record did not argue their case. Women refusing sugar in 1791 did not debate abolition at the table; they put the sugar bowl away. A German artist setting brass stones into pavements since 1992 explains nothing on the stone. The question those movements were answering was not "is this right?" but "what if this were possible?" — and the answer was the thing itself.

The pattern. Open with a question, not a claim: *what if this were possible?* A question cannot be rebutted, only answered, and the way to answer it is to build the thing and let time check it. The question is the door out of both comfort zones at once. Everything that follows in this language is a way of answering it honestly.

Connections. *Supports:* every pattern below — it is the frame they fill. *Connects to:* Say What Failure Looks Like (Pattern 7), because a question that cannot be answered "no" is a claim in disguise.

Open questions. Whether the question survives translation into audiences whose language has no idiomatic *what if*; whether it can be asked without being heard as a slogan.

Status. Converged.

Ring 1 — The point

Pattern 2 — One Subject, Revisitable

The tension. Advocacy wants scale, and the mind cannot feel scale. One identifiable person moves us; the numbing begins as early as the second face; a thousand is a statistic. But a single subject shown once is a burst, and bursts are what the field already has too many of.

What was observed. The AIDS quilt is fifty thousand panels, each the size of one grave, each one person. The stones

are one name each. The tree movement in Kenya counted trees one at a time to fifty-one million. In each case the unit of encounter stayed single while the count grew — and the subject was somewhere you could go back to. Compassion collapse and pseudoinefficacy are named, replicated findings; the single subject is not a style choice but a cognitive limit.

The pattern. Make the unit of encounter one real subject in one real place that can be returned to. Aggregate elsewhere — in the count, the map, the index — never in the encounter. A subject that cannot be revisited is a picture; a subject that can is evidence.

Connections. *Depends on:* The Person Shown Owns the Showing (Pattern 3). *Supports:* Show It Again (Pattern 5). *Connects to:* Empty Region Held Empty (Pattern 4).

Open questions. At what count does the index itself become the spectacle, and the single subject a token?

Status. Converged; the cognitive limit measured.

Pattern 3 — The Person Shown Owns the Showing

The tension. Advocacy needs the story, and the story belongs to someone. The field's default is extraction — take the testimony, carry it to the audience, add a consent form afterward. The person is material. Everything downstream inherits that.

What was observed. The strongest membership movements in the record were run by the people shown: the mothers in Buenos Aires were the movement; the quilt panels were sewn by the dead person's own people; each stone is made only after the family is asked; #MeToo was testimony at scale with zero extraction because every post was the poster's own story, under their own name, at their own risk. Where the person shown owned the showing, the campaign outlasted its founders. Where they were material — the viral video of 2012, the helpless continent of 1985 — the campaign left the wrong picture behind.

The pattern. Consent is architecture, not compliance. The person shown decides how far the showing travels and how long it stays, before anything goes out; belonging attaches to their contribution; withdrawal stays possible along the whole trace. They are a member of the thing, never its content.

Connections. *Depends on:* Built to Survive Hostile Re-use (Pattern 14) — consent for a campaign is a different consent from consent for a quiet record. *Supports:* Pattern 2; The Unit You Share (Pattern 8). *Connects to:* The Swing Pushes Back (Pattern 12).

Open questions. How consent scales without compressing — growth is bounded by real conversations, and no known shortcut leaves the pattern intact.

Status. Converged.

Pattern 4 — Empty Region Held Empty

The tension. A half-empty map, a half-told story, a region with no point in it — every instinct says fill it: a composite, a placeholder, a representative case. The audience will not know. The hostile reader will.

What was observed. Every fabrication in the record was found, and the finding cost more than the gap would have. The organisation behind the 2012 video closed. Programmes that could not fail visibly — the anti-drug curriculum, the scare-them-straight prison visits — survived their own null results for years, then were found to have done harm. Trust, once read as manufactured, does not return.

The pattern. No fabricated subjects, no composites, no placeholder presented as real. Scaffolding is always flagged as scaffolding. An empty region is the correct answer until real, consented material exists. The gap is the evidence of the standard.

Connections. *Depends on:* Pattern 3. *Supports:* Say What Failure Looks Like (Pattern 7); Time Against Volume (Pattern 13), since only what is verifiable outlasts volume. *Connects to:* the sincerity condition in the case history — the faked stimulus gets no response.

Open questions. How to show that a region is empty on purpose, so the emptiness reads as discipline and not as absence.

Status. Designed as a rule; converged as a practice — the stones and the quilt never faked a name.

Ring 2 — The work

Pattern 5 — Show It Again

The tension. The feed rewards the burst and forgets in days. A campaign built for one exposure gets one exposure. But the same thing shown twice looks like repetition, and repetition of an argument fatigues.

What was observed. The successes that lasted were decades long — the mothers every Thursday from 1977, the stones from 1992, the trees from 1977. The same place seen again, further grown, was the argument; nothing was said twice, but something was shown twice. Psychology supplies the engine: familiarity breeds liking with no argument occurring; a real, particular person seen repeatedly at a distance works on the mind like a neighbour; spaced exposure outlasts massed. The measured counter-case is the platform-era spike: support at 67 per cent in June 2020, 51 by 2023.

The pattern. Publish only what can be revisited, and put the return into the form itself — a schedule the audience can fall into step with. The revisit is the argument. Repetition of a demonstration accumulates; repetition of a claim decays.

Connections. *Depends on:* Pattern 2. *Supports:* Time Against Volume (Pattern 13) — duration is the one thing a firehose cannot counterfeit. *Connects to:* Choose Your Swing (Pattern 10), which sets the rhythm's reach.

Open questions. What the minimum honest interval is before a return reads as growth rather than as the same picture again.

Status. Converged; the mechanisms measured.

Pattern 6 — Doors, Not a Hand on the Back

The tension. The advocate knows what the audience should conclude, and wants to say so. But a message experienced as pressure produces push-back, up to the boomerang; an authority instructing teenagers not to take drugs is a machine for producing exactly the opposite.

What was observed. The best-measured success in advocacy — the teen anti-smoking campaign that recouped its own cost — never told anyone to obey; it exposed the industry and let the audience finish the meaning as rebellion. The stones do not explain. The tree has no caption. In deep canvassing, the strongest durable attitude shift in the literature, the listener does most of the talking. Attitudes change most when people articulate the case in their own words.

The pattern. No narrator, no ask, no caption drawing the conclusion. The audience completes the meaning or nothing happens. On-ramps exist — follow, twin, fund, visit — but every on-ramp is a door, never a hand on the back. The only conversion that counts is the step the viewer takes as their own.

Connections. *Depends on:* Pattern 1 — a question leaves the answer to the audience. *Supports:* The Unit You Share (Pattern 8). *Connects to:* The Trimtab (Pattern 9) — placement, not push.

Open questions. Whether a form with no narrator can hold in a medium that inserts one — a platform's own captioning, a curator's framing.

Status. Measured.

Pattern 7 — Say What Failure Looks Like

The tension. Almost no campaign states in advance what its own failure would look like — so budgets outlive evidence, and the programme that cannot fail visibly lasts longest. Falsifiability feels like weakness in a room that wants confidence.

What was observed. The anti-drug media campaign spent over \$1.4 billion and was found not effective, with possible delayed adverse effects; nothing in its design could be seen to fail. The one literature that published its own failure — deep canvassing, a 2014 study retracted, a 2016 replication that held — came out stronger. Esperanto ran for more than a century on duration, membership, and demonstration and never tipped, because nobody named what actually stopped people.

The pattern. State the predicted result before the first input, including the expected near-null after a single exposure. Run a hostile-read round that can remove whole classes of content before they are built. Name the failure conditions, and the audience's blocking belief — diagnosed, not assumed. Publish the nulls. A method that cannot say what would disprove it is a belief.

Connections. *Depends on:* Pattern 4. *Supports:* Choose Your Swing (Pattern 10), which sets what is measured. *Connects to:* Pattern 1 — the question's honest "no."

Open questions. What instrument measures a crack rather than a conversion; how a small project reads public polling as terrain without commissioning any.

Status. Designed — the converged cases never carried it by intent; it is what deliberate design adds.

Pattern 8 — The Unit You Share

The tension. The platforms amplify. Everyone wants the amplification. But the same amplifier that made the 2012 video the most viral of its era gave it a two-year half-life and a sequel nobody watched.

What was observed. Hand the platform a message and you get a spike and a fade. Hand it an act people perform themselves — my story under my name, my bucket of ice water, my abstained sugar — and each share is itself a small demonstration, and the effect accumulates: #MeToo, the ice-bucket summer, the sugar boycott. One photograph in 2015

measured both halves at once: daily donations rose a hundredfold and faded almost as fast, while monthly sign-ups rose tenfold and almost none cancelled. The people the burst turned into members stayed.

The pattern. A message decays; a membership act accumulates. Design the shareable unit as an act the sharer performs, not a message they forward. The unit you share decides everything the platform will do with it.

Connections. *Depends on:* Pattern 3 — the act belongs to the person who performs it. *Supports:* Show It Again (Pattern 5). *Connects to:* Time Against Volume (Pattern 13).

Open questions. How an act stays an act when the platform converts it to a template — the point at which a gesture becomes a share.

Status. Measured.

Ring 3 — The carriers

Pattern 9 — The Trimtab

The tension. The audience is heavy and the advocate is small. Pushing directly costs more than any small project has, and the record says bought reach for a message is the most expensive way to produce nothing.

What was observed. On a great ship the rudder is too heavy to push directly, so a small tab on the rudder's edge turns the rudder, and the rudder turns the ship. A fund holding two hundredths of a per cent of the largest oil company won three board seats by persuading the few giant index holders whose votes turn it — not by fighting the ship. The smiling-sun logo of a fifty-year movement was never bought; it travelled through carrier networks. Placement before volume; carriers before crowds.

The pattern. Do not push the audience. Place one small, true, well-made thing where the medium's own flow is already moving — the twinning, the aid group, the local newsletter, the teacher — and let the flow do the work. The trimtab has a second meaning, from aircraft, and it may be the truer one: fitted so the pilot is not worn out holding a course.

Connections. *Depends on:* Pattern 6. *Supports:* Choose Your Swing (Pattern 10); One Drop Point (Pattern 11). *Connects to:* the receiver-side energy in the case history — the response is built from what the audience already holds.

Open questions. Whether a trimtab can be identified in advance or only in hindsight; how many carriers a single point can hold before it is no longer a point.

Status. Converged; the financial case measured.

Pattern 10 — Choose Your Swing

The tension. Every funder's criteria ask for reach, and every campaign claims both reach and depth. But depth of response and breadth of audience trade off — for oscillators, by theorem; for anything human, as a design heuristic that has never been repealed.

What was observed. Someone pushing a child on a swing has the whole method in their hands: small force, matched to a rhythm already there, at the right moment, many times. Push out of time and the swing dies; push harder out of time and it still dies. One swing can be pushed deep; a playground can be pushed shallow; not both. The record's deepest successes tuned sharply to a few whose own audiences then moved with them.

The pattern. Choose selectivity, and say which. A narrow, well-defined audience with a deep, accumulating response is a legitimate and usually superior choice to broad reach with fast decay. Name the choice per campaign, because it also chooses what is measured: a campaign tuned to a narrow band will not move a national poll, and expecting it to is a category error. Most criteria offer targeted influence as an alternative to mass reach; take it, out loud.

Connections. *Depends on:* Pattern 9. *Supports:* Say What Failure Looks Like (Pattern 7) — the instrument follows the choice. *Connects to:* One Drop Point (Pattern 11).

Open questions. How a narrow-band success is later widened without losing the depth that made it — whether a second swing can be pushed from the first.

Status. Designed; the trade-off observed, not measured in advocacy.

Pattern 11 — One Drop Point

The tension. A good idea wants to be everywhere at once. But inputs that are out of phase with each other cancel: drop the same thing into five audiences on five rhythms and you have spent five inputs to produce nothing anyone can feel.

What was observed. Two images hold the decision. The pebble into the pond: one strike, and the medium's own coupling carries the wave outward from a single entry. The small hammer on the mountain: the same spot, returned to, blow after patient blow. They differ in what follows — propagation outward, accumulation in place — and both agree that

the entry point is one, and chosen.

The pattern. One entry point, one rhythm, proven or falsified, then the next. Choose it against stated criteria: a rhythm already running, not still water; a carrier whose own audience demonstrably follows them; low damping — the moveable middle, not a band already saturated to futility; a medium that structurally supports return (a newsletter can; a feed cannot); and survivable placement — consent, safety, and capture design travel with the input, and a drop point that exposes anyone is disqualified whatever its coupling.

Connections. *Depends on:* Patterns 9 and 10. *Supports:* Show It Again (Pattern 5) — the rhythm is set here. *Connects to:* Built to Survive Hostile Re-use (Pattern 14).

Open questions. Whether the first drop point is ever really a choice — the room in which the work is first shown is the default unless deliberately declined — so the real decision is the second.

Status. Designed.

Pattern 12 — The Swing Pushes Back

The tension. Physics leaves the driver unmoved. Advocacy borrows the physics and forgets that every human account of the same phenomenon — two millennia apart — insists that both parties change, or it was not response. A campaign that cannot be altered by its audience is broadcasting with better manners.

What was observed. The lived concepts of mutual work — toloka, dugnad, meitheal, imece, harambee, bayanihan — all put belonging after the contribution: the log you carried, not the speech you made. The Kenyan trees fed the women who planted them and changed the movement's own shape as they did. Working with, not for, is not a courtesy; it is the two-way condition.

The pattern. What comes back from the audience must be able to alter the work — its form, its subjects, its schedule. Build the return path into the design, and let the audience's own step — join, twin, fund, visit — be the membership, with the campaign being what those steps add up to.

Connections. *Depends on:* Pattern 3. *Supports:* Say What Failure Looks Like (Pattern 7) — feedback is also evidence. *Connects to:* the mutual-transformation finding in the case history.

Open questions. How much the work may change before it is no longer the work — the boundary between responsiveness and drift.

Status. Converged as practice; designed as rule.

Ring 4 — The environment

Pattern 13 — Time Against Volume

The tension. The information environment is shaped by an adversarial method — high volume, many channels, no commitment to truth or consistency — whose product is not belief but exhaustion: the feeling that nothing can be known and nothing done. Matching it with volume loses by construction.

What was observed. Read as design rather than content, the firehose is a damping strategy: incoherent volume raises everyone's friction until no signal can accumulate. It has learned to buy rather than build — a 2024 indictment showed one commentator on four hundred thousand dollars a month — and synthetic generation is collapsing the cost of fabrication toward zero. But it has one structural weakness: it can fake any single picture and any single story, and it cannot fake the same real place, revisited, over years. A lie must be maintained; a garden only watered. Four hundred thousand a month for one rented voice; one hundred and twenty euros for one permanent stone.

The pattern. Against a damping strategy, coherence over time is the one thing that still accumulates. Build a small set of things that are always checkable — verified, provenanced, returned to — and let time do what volume cannot. Time against volume is the asymmetric answer, and it costs almost nothing.

Connections. *Depends on:* Patterns 4 and 5. *Supports:* the whole language — it is the reason the language exists. *Connects to:* Pattern 8.

Open questions. Damping may win; against sufficiently manufactured futility, coherence over time is the best available answer and still may not accumulate. No pattern here can promise otherwise.

Status. Measured in its adversary; designed in its answer.

Pattern 14 — Built to Survive Hostile Re-use

The tension. Everything published can be turned. The same craft that carries a memorial has carried tyrannies; the same model that finds a community's frequency lets a wrecker attack it through that frequency with small force — a

precise description of targeted disinformation. Advocacy in a hostile environment, about real people in real places, has costs the people carry and the campaign does not.

What was observed. The 1985 sympathy campaign built the wrong permanent picture of a continent, still contested forty years on. The 2012 video's extraction was exactly what its subjects' backlash was about. A tapestry at the United Nations was covered over during a war briefing because everyone in the building knew what it argued. Craft guarantees nothing; only design against capture does.

The pattern. Build every output to survive hostile re-use, and when in doubt, leave it unpublished. Exclude by design the classes of subject whose exposure cannot be made safe — in wartime: children, precise places, schedules tied to named people; no gate opens this. Hand no adversary a frequency map of the community shown — what moves them, when, through whom. Sometimes declining synchrony is the design: soldiers break step on a bridge.

Connections. *Depends on:* Pattern 3 — consent that names the reach and the permanence is the first capture defence. *Supports:* Patterns 4 and 11. *Connects to:* every pattern in Ring 1.

Open questions. Who decides "in doubt" when the person shown wants exposure the designer judges unsafe — the pattern says the designer declines, and says why.

Status. Designed; its failures converged.

Assembling your own

The cards are meant to be laid out, not read through. A way to begin:

1. Write Pattern 1 as a sentence about your own situation: *what if ___ were possible?*
2. Choose Ring 1 first — one real subject, one owner. If you cannot name both, stop; the language has nothing to say yet.
3. Take the four Ring 2 cards as four promises, and test them together: any three without the fourth collapse into something the world already has — duration without ownership is surveillance; ownership without showing is a newsletter; showing without a failure test is faith.
4. Choose your swing and your drop point (Ring 3) before your first input, and write the predicted response and the failure condition down with them.
5. Read the result against Ring 4 as a hostile reader would, before one does.

Then the five questions the whole language reduces to: Is there a real thing I can come back to? Does the person shown own it, or am I using them? Can it stand without a narrator? What would tell me it isn't working? What is the one belief actually stopping my audience — named, not guessed?

Where the depth is

- *Advocacy — Methods, Record, and a Trimtab Alternative* — the record, the taxonomy of methods, the psychology, the adversary, the method with its instruments; every figure and its source.
- *Advocacy — A Short Guide for Trimtabs* — the same argument in plain language, English and Ukrainian.
- *Resonance — A Case History* — the observation behind Patterns 10, 11, and 12, and what that observation does not license.
- *A Trimtab Method — Stated Generally* — the four commitments and three design rules, abstracted for any domain.

Provenance

Derived from `whatif_pattern_language_advocacy_EN_v0_1.md` (v0.1) by `tools/build_oer_edition.py` on 2026-09-05. Removed for this edition: the drafting notes only — this document was written generic from the start; the source's changelog and drafting notes. The method, the record, every figure, and every source are unchanged. This edition is licensed CC BY-SA 4.0 and is written to be taken, changed, and outgrown.

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